



Partly sunny 59/47 • Tomorrow: Shower, mist 70/64 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Schumer will vote for bill to avert shutdown

Enough Democrats will back GOP's funding plan, senator has said privately

BY LIZ GOODWIN, THEODORIC MEYER AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer (D-New York) said Thursday that he plans to support the GOP funding bill, lowering the odds of a government shutdown.

"For sure the Republican bill is a terrible option," Schumer said on the Senate floor. "But I believe allowing Donald Trump to take ... much more power via a government shutdown is a far worse option."

Schumer has privately told senators there are enough Democratic votes to avert a shutdown, according to three people with knowledge of the interactions who spoke on the condition of anonymity to avoid disclosing private discussions.

The federal government is set to shut down at 12:01 a.m. Saturday unless lawmakers pass a bill to keep it open. Senate Republicans are likely to need eight Democrats to join them in order to overcome the Senate's 60-vote filibuster threshold, and only one Democrat aside from Schumer has publicly said he will support the bill.

Schumer's announcement comes just a day after he said there were not enough Democrats to support the bill and as the caucus faces intense pressure from liberal grassroots voters and Democratic members of the House to oppose it.

Schumer has presided over three days of wrenching debate among Senate Democrats over

SEE SHUTDOWN ON A5

D.C. budget cuts: Hundreds ask senators to reject spending bill. **B1**



RICKY CARIOTI/THE WASHINGTON POST

From left, Republican Sens. Markwayne Mullin (Oklahoma), Tim Scott (South Carolina), Roger Marshall (Kansas) and Jon Husted (Ohio) are among the members of the Senate health committee. Dave Weldon had been set to testify at a committee hearing Thursday.

White House abruptly withdraws pick to lead CDC

BY LENA H. SUN, DAN DIAMOND, RACHEL ROUBEIN AND FENIT NIRAPPI

The White House abruptly abandoned the nomination of Dave Weldon, the former Florida congressman who questioned vaccine safety, to lead the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention on Thursday amid concerns he could not be confirmed by the Senate.

The move leaves the Trump administration in search of a leader for the agency — which formulates vaccine policy recommendations — as a growing measles outbreak highlights criticism of the agency's public health response.

The Senate health committee

Weldon, scrutinized for vaccine views, appeared to lack Senate support

announced Weldon's nomination had been pulled shortly before he was scheduled to testify at a hearing Thursday morning.

The withdrawal of Weldon's nomination marks a rare setback for a Trump administration pick. The Senate has confirmed every controversial choice brought to a full vote on the floor to date.

Weldon, a 71-year-old doctor who left Congress in 2009, drew scrutiny for his longtime promotion of the false claim that vac-

cines can cause autism.

In a four-page statement released Thursday, Weldon said a White House assistant called him Wednesday night to inform him his nomination was being withdrawn because he lacked the votes to be confirmed. Weldon, who again raised concerns about routine vaccines in his statement, said Republican senators concerned about his vaccine views doomed his nomination and that he suspected the pharmaceutical industry also played a role.

"The president is a busy man doing good work for our nation and the last thing he needs is a controversy about CDC," Weldon wrote, later adding, "Hopefully they can find someone for CDC who can survive the confirmation

process and get past pharma and find some answers."

The White House push to abandon Weldon was partly driven by concerns about the political consequences of his vaccine views, according to three people familiar with the matter who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe internal deliberations.

Meanwhile, the Senate health committee advanced the nominees to lead two other major health agencies — the National Institutes of Health and the Food and Drug Administration — to a vote of the full Senate.

A growing measles outbreak concentrated in Texas has become a cautionary tale for the consequences of low immunization

SEE WELDON ON A6

Workers must be rehired, judge says

RULING COVERS MULTIPLE AGENCIES

OPM lacked authority to fire probationary staffers

BY SALVADOR RIZZO

SAN FRANCISCO — A federal judge on Thursday ordered the Trump administration to immediately offer jobs back to thousands of probationary workers who were fired last month under directions from the Office of Personnel Management, complicating President Donald Trump's efforts to shrink the federal workforce.

U.S. District Judge William Alsup said at a court hearing that the personnel office — which serves as the federal government's human resources agency — had no legal authority to direct the mass firings in conference calls and written communications last month. He added that individual agencies could downsize their staffs by following the steps laid out in the federal Reduction in Force Act, a process that administration officials have already put in motion.

The ruling marks the most significant challenge so far to Trump's campaign to shrink and reshape the sprawling, 2.3-million-person federal workforce. That effort, championed by Trump's billionaire adviser Elon Musk, has sparked mounting legal and administrative challenges across the country. Thursday's decision comes in a suit filed by

SEE EMPLOYEES ON A9

Agency spending freeze: DOGE takes aim at purchase cards. **A4**

IRS cuts: Top lawyer ousted as DOGE seeks access to records. **A7**

Philip Kennicott: A precarious future for federally owned art. **C1**

Putin demurs on ceasefire deal, sets stiff conditions

BY ROBYN DIXON, MARY ILYUSHINA, LIZZIE JOHNSON AND ISAAC ARNSDORF

Russian President Vladimir Putin refused Thursday to fully embrace a U.S. proposal for a ceasefire in the Ukraine war, saying there are "nuances" that require "painstaking research," especially since Russian forces are advancing in the war.

President Donald Trump, speaking in the Oval Office after Putin's remarks, said the Russian leader "put out a very promising statement, but it was incomplete. And yeah, I'd love to meet with him or talk to him, but we have to get it over with fast."

The Russian leader was due to meet Trump's envoy Steve Witkoff on Thursday evening to discuss the ceasefire proposal, which earlier one of Putin's top aides had dismissed as unworkable. Putin's comments allow Russia to engage in protracted negotiations without immediately rejecting a truce.

Putin, who thanked Trump for his efforts to resolve the conflict,

SEE CEASEFIRE ON A12

Intelligence: Reports suggest Putin still aims to dominate Ukraine. **A13**



RACHEL WOOLF/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

What's being lost with DOGE's cuts? Fired federal workers can tell you.

Neesha Regmi Schnepf, a former research scientist at the U.S. Geological Survey, and other dismissed government employees explain their jobs and how the elimination of them could alter life in America. **Story, A8-9**

JOHN FEINSTEIN 1955-2025

Sportswriter shone a light on both titans, underdogs

BY MATT SCHUDEL

John Feinstein, a Washington Post sportswriter who became the best-selling author of more than 40 books, including "A Season on the Brink," an inside look at volatile Indiana University men's basketball coach Bob Knight, died March 13 at his brother's home in McLean, Virginia. He was 69.

His brother, Robert Feinstein, confirmed the death and said the cause may have been a heart attack.

Mr. Feinstein (pronounced Fine-steen) joined The Post in 1977 as a night police reporter but soon distinguished himself on the sports beat.

He covered a wide range of subjects and developed a talent for deep sourcing that fed personality-driven and dramatic narratives about athletes, coaches and management. One of the most popular sports authors of his era, he also became a frequent commentator on NPR, ESPN and the Golf Channel and had radio programs on Sirius XM.

He wrote books about baseball, football, tennis, golf and the Olympics, as well as novels for young readers, but he was perhaps best known for his coverage



MITCHELL LAYTON/GETTY IMAGES

John Feinstein built a career and life by fostering ties, writes The Post's Barry Svrluga. D1

of college basketball. With an indefatigable work ethic, Mr. Feinstein filed a day before his death a column for The Post on Michigan State men's basketball coach Tom Izzo.

In 1985, Mr. Feinstein took a leave of absence from The Post to follow the Indiana Hoosiers and their coach, Knight, for the season.

Knight, who had already won

SEE FEINSTEIN ON A18

IN THE NEWS

Birthright citizenship fight The Trump administration asked the Supreme Court to allow the president's ban issued via executive order to go forward in some states. **A18**

Covid's mark on D.C.-area schools A parent, a teacher and students reflect on the anxiety and learning loss that persist five years on. **B1**

THE NATION **Mahmoud Khalil's** arrest flouts the Constitution and seeks to muzzle others, experts said. **A3** **All migrants** still detained at Guantánamo Bay were flown back to the United States. **A7**

THE WORLD **A U.N. report** accused Israel of sexual violence and "genocidal acts" in its war in Gaza. **A11** **The discovery** of a Mexican drug cartel's "extermination camp" prompted outrage. **A10**

THE ECONOMY **Waymo's robot taxis** are programmed to follow the rules of the road but got 589 parking tickets in San Francisco last year. **A14** **The S&P 500** entered correction territory, having fallen more than 10 percent from a record close last month. **A14**

THE REGION **The top Democrat** on the House judiciary panel is seeking an investigation of D.C.'s interim U.S. attorney. **B1** **Maryland lawmakers** moved to empower the state's first-in-the-nation drug affordability board to bring down medication costs. **B1**

STYLE **Fox News** and President Donald Trump are growing ever closer, as he continues to tap network staff to join his administration. **C1**

WEEKEND **Tom Sietsema** offers a list of his top eight D.C.-area Ethiopian restaurants.

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